
A First Trip

Plan for catching, not for fishing

How to take somebody fishing who has never been

The failure mode of a first trip is always the same: an adult who wants to catch a good fish takes a beginner to a place where good fish live, and the beginner spends four hours not catching anything and concludes that fishing is boring. They are right. Plan the opposite trip.



HOOKLESS PRACTICE ON GRASS



SHORT FIXED-FLOAT SESSION



WET SUPPORT AT WATER LEVEL

The plan

Target bluegill	Not bass, not walleye, not "whatever bites". In June a bluegill bed will produce a fish every few minutes, and constant action is the entire point. <i>see the Bluegill sheet</i>
Go in June	Late May through June, when panfish are on the beds in 1–4 ft of water and you can see them. Pine Lake spot 6 ; North Lake spot 1 .
Go in the evening	Two hours before dark, not eight in the morning. Warmer, calmer, better bite, and a natural end to the trip.
Keep it short	Ninety minutes. Leave while it is still fun. The trip should end because you decided to end it, not because somebody has stopped enjoying it.
One rod each	A short spinning rod, 4 lb line, a fixed bobber a couple of feet above a size 8 hook, half a worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i> — but use a fixed float, not a slip float, for the first trip.
Pinch the barbs	Flatten every barb with pliers. You will lose a few fish and you will save yourself the one memory that ends the hobby: a barbed hook in a finger, an hour from the car.

What to bring

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Rod, already rigged, at home• A spare rod, also already rigged• Worms, more than you think• Long-nose pliers• Nail clippers for line• Landing net• Wet towel | <ul style="list-style-type: none">• Life jackets that fit <i>them</i>• Sunscreen and a hat• Bug spray• Snacks and water — more than the fishing gear, honestly• Something to keep fish in, if keeping• A first-aid kit with tweezers |
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The first hour, in order

1. Rig both rods at home.

2. Pinch each barb flat with pliers.
3. Pull each knot hard.
4. Cover each hook for transport.
5. Put the fitted life jacket on the beginner.
6. Put your own life jacket on.
7. Clip a hookless casting plug to one rod.
8. Stand on grass with everyone behind the caster.
9. Demonstrate one short underhand flip.
10. Let the beginner make five flips.
11. Stop practice when the plug lands forward without crossing anyone.
12. Replace the plug with the covered fishing rig.
13. Uncover the hook only at the fishing position.
14. Set the float so the bait rides just above the visible bed.
15. Let the beginner bait, cast, watch, and reel.
16. Hand over the spare rod immediately when the first rod tangles.
17. Net the first fish at water level.
18. Wet both sets of hands.
19. Support the fish horizontally.
20. Identify one visible feature.
21. Release the fish before preparing the next cast.
22. Leave at 90 minutes or while the beginner still wants one more cast, whichever comes first.

Checks and stop branches

Practice passes only when every cast travels forward and the hookless plug stays clear of people. Fishing passes only when the life jacket remains fitted, the hook is controlled, and the adult can reach the beginner. If thunder, strong wind, unsafe footing, cold stress, panic, or repeated hook-control loss appears, stop and leave. If no fish contacts the bait in 15 minutes, shorten the depth once; after another 15 minutes, move once or switch to looking for aquatic life rather than extending the trip.

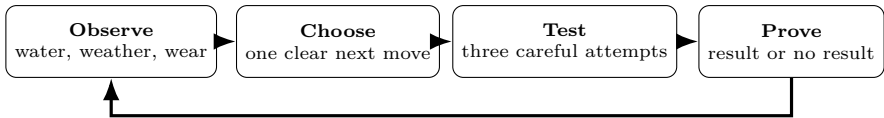
Things that go wrong, and the fix

Problem	Fix
Tangles	Inevitable. Carry the pre-rigged spare rod, hand it over, and untangle the first one later. Do not make a child stand and watch you pick at a bird's nest for ten minutes.
Nothing biting	You are in the wrong spot or too deep. Move shallower, go smaller, use less bait. Half a worm out-fishes a whole one for panfish every time.
Bored	The bite has slowed. Change activity rather than persisting: look at what is in the water, catch a crayfish under a rock, throw the cast net, go home. Fishing is not the only good thing about being at a lake.
Hook in a finger	This is why the barbs are pinched. Back it out the way it went in, clean it, plaster on it, carry on. With a barb still on, cut the line and see a doctor.
Frightened of the fish	Normal. Hold it yourself first, let them touch it while you hold it, and do not push. They will pick one up within a couple of trips.

The measure of success

Not the size of the fish, and not how many. The measure is whether they ask to go again. Everything on this sheet is arranged to make that answer yes.

Use a closed-loop check



Question	Check	Recovery
What changed?	Name one visible or measurable fact: wind direction, depth, water temperature, abrasion, knot shape, lure track, fish reflex, or elapsed time.	If you cannot name the change, observe for one minute before changing equipment.
What am I testing?	Change one variable only and state what success will look like before the attempt.	Restore the last known setup; avoid changing lure, depth, speed, and location together.
Is the system sound?	Trace the full chain from hand to fish: line, knot, leader, hook, drag, handling tool, route home.	Stop on any rough line, crossed wrap, open snap, dull point, missing tool, or unsafe condition; repair or leave.
What proves completion?	A repeatable result and a final tactile/visual check, not merely finishing the written steps.	Repeat slowly under good light. If the check is ambiguous, treat it as a failure.

Final proof before the next cast

Say the plan in one sentence. Tug-test the terminal connection, touch-check the last two feet of line, confirm hook point and snap closure, set the drag, and identify the safe landing and release route. If weather, visibility, footing, or fish condition makes that route doubtful, change the plan before casting.

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First-trip worksheet

Before leaving home

Proof	Recorded result / correction
Live rule and weather checked	
Return time told to another adult	
Life jackets fitted and buckled	
Two rods rigged; barbs flattened	
Hookless plug and hook covers packed	
Food, water, sun, insects, first aid	

Trip checkpoints

Time	Observable check	Pass, correction, or stop
Arrival	Wind, footing, jackets, hook control	
After practice	Five forward hookless flips	
15 minutes	Contact, depth, attention	
30 minutes	Contact after one change	
First fish	Net, wet hands, support, release	
Departure	Head count, hooks covered, site clean	

Proof after the trip

Beginner did independently:

Frustration appeared when:

The adult changed:

Evidence the session ended in time:

One change before the next trip: